What the professor expects when they open the portal

A UX note, written 2026-10-23. It describes the professor's work as they experience it — by the calendar, by the week, by the deadline — and puts the pane's places against it, to find where the portal answers a question the professor is not asking yet, and where it makes them assemble an answer by hand. The diagrams are Mermaid; GitHub and VS Code draw them.

Companions: `WORKFLOWS.md` (how a process is modelled — a case, not a flowchart) and `EXAM-GRADING.md` (one process end to end). `COURSE-MODE.md` is the layout this note assumes.

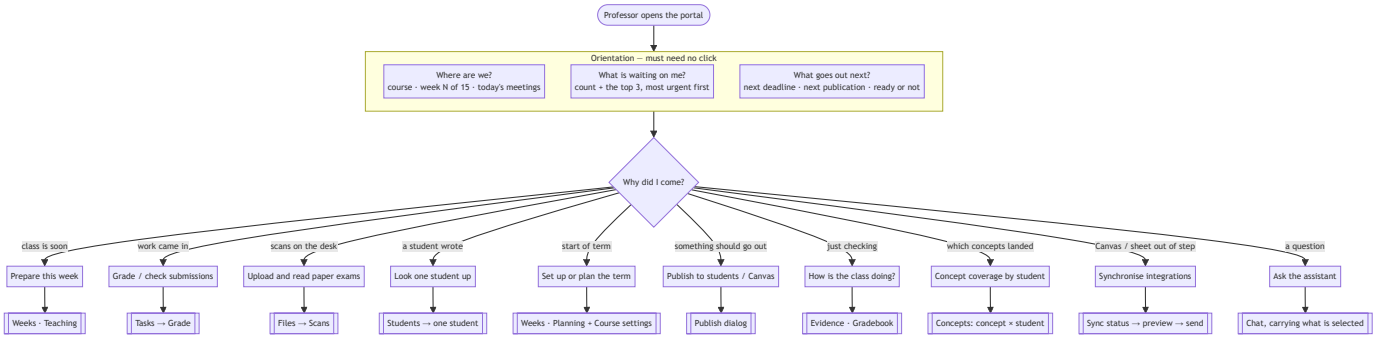
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1 · The first five seconds

A professor does not open the portal to browse. They open it because something on the calendar moved: a class tomorrow, a deadline last night, a stack of scans on the desk, an email from a student. Before they press anything they want three answers, in this order:

1. **Where are we?** Which course, which week, what happens today.
2. **What is waiting on me?** Not everything open — the things only I can do, most urgent first, with a count.
3. **What goes out next?** What students will see or receive soon, and whether it is ready.

Everything else — the gradebook, concepts, settings — is a place they go *because* one of those three answers sent them there.

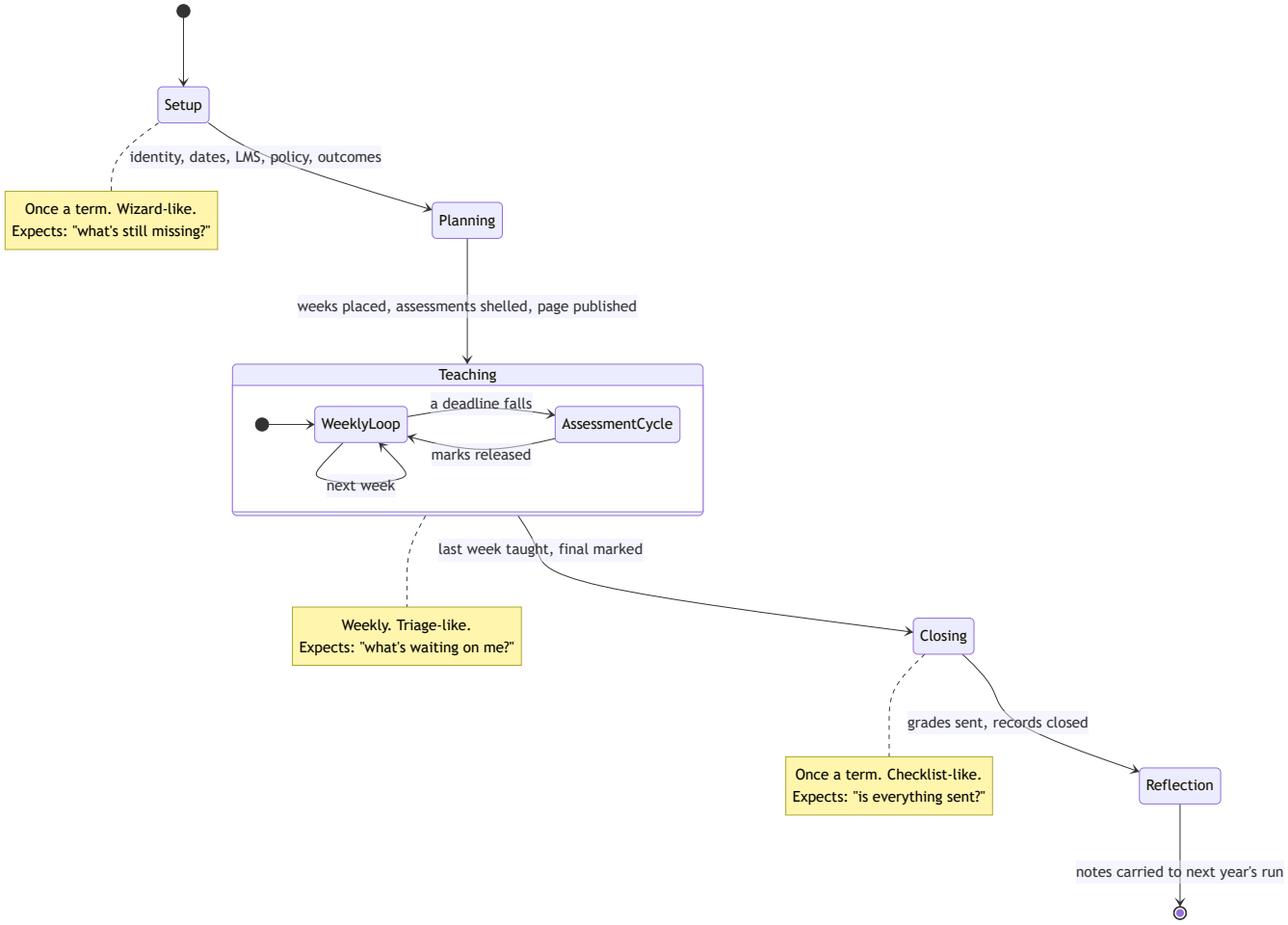


What this asks of the landing. Today the centre opens on a chat's empty page, and the three answers are spread between the navigator (course, this week, two counts) and places the professor has to open. The landing they expect is a **Today** card in the centre: this week's meetings, the waiting count with its top items as buttons, and the next thing due or going out — each item one press from the place that resolves it. The chat's text field sits at its foot, as it already does on an open place.

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2 · The term, as the professor lives it

The professor's year has a shape, and what they expect from the same portal changes with it. In week 0 they want structure; in week 6 they want a to-do list; in week 15 they want a summary.



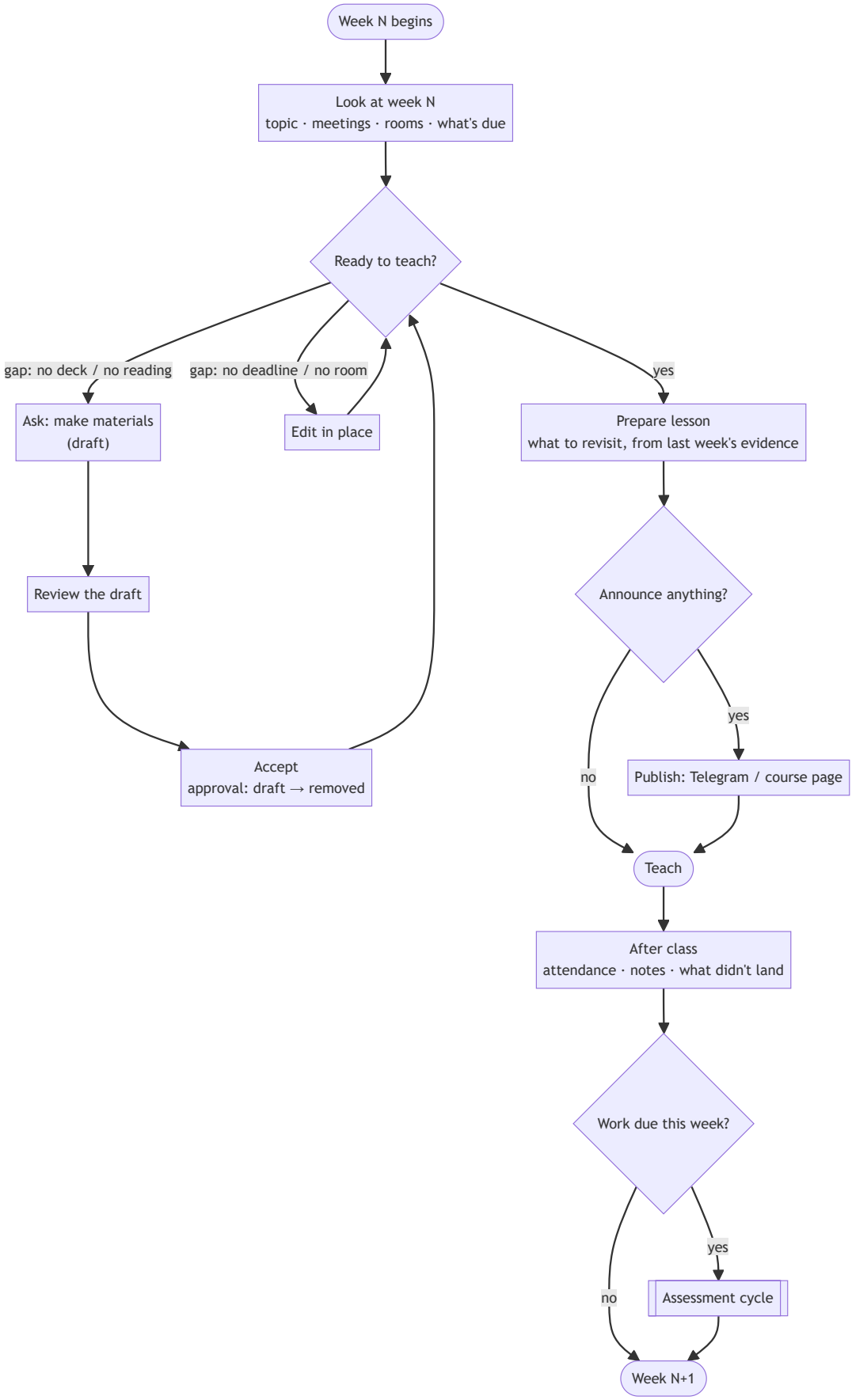
Phase	The professor's question	Where the portal should put them	Today
Setup	What is still missing before I can plan?	a readiness checklist, one item at a time	`/onboard-course` in chat; Course settings
Planning	Is every week ready to teach?	Weeks · Planning with the Gaps tally	built
Teaching	What do I do this week?	Today → Weeks · Teaching	navigator's *This week*; no Today
Assessment	Where is each piece of work?	the assessment's own strip	chips on the week; Scans has a strip, others don't
Closing	Has everything gone out, is anything unmarked?	a close checklist	nowhere (EXAM-GRADING *Close* — *gap*)
Reflection	What should change next year?	`/course-reflection`, seeded with Evidence	chat only

The landing should know the phase. Before term starts, *Today* is a readiness list; during term it is the week; after the final it is the close checklist. The phase is computed from the run's dates and records, never stored — the rule `WORKFLOWS.md` §2 already set.

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3 · The weekly loop

Most visits happen here. The unit is the week, and the loop runs roughly from the weekend before a class to the day after it.



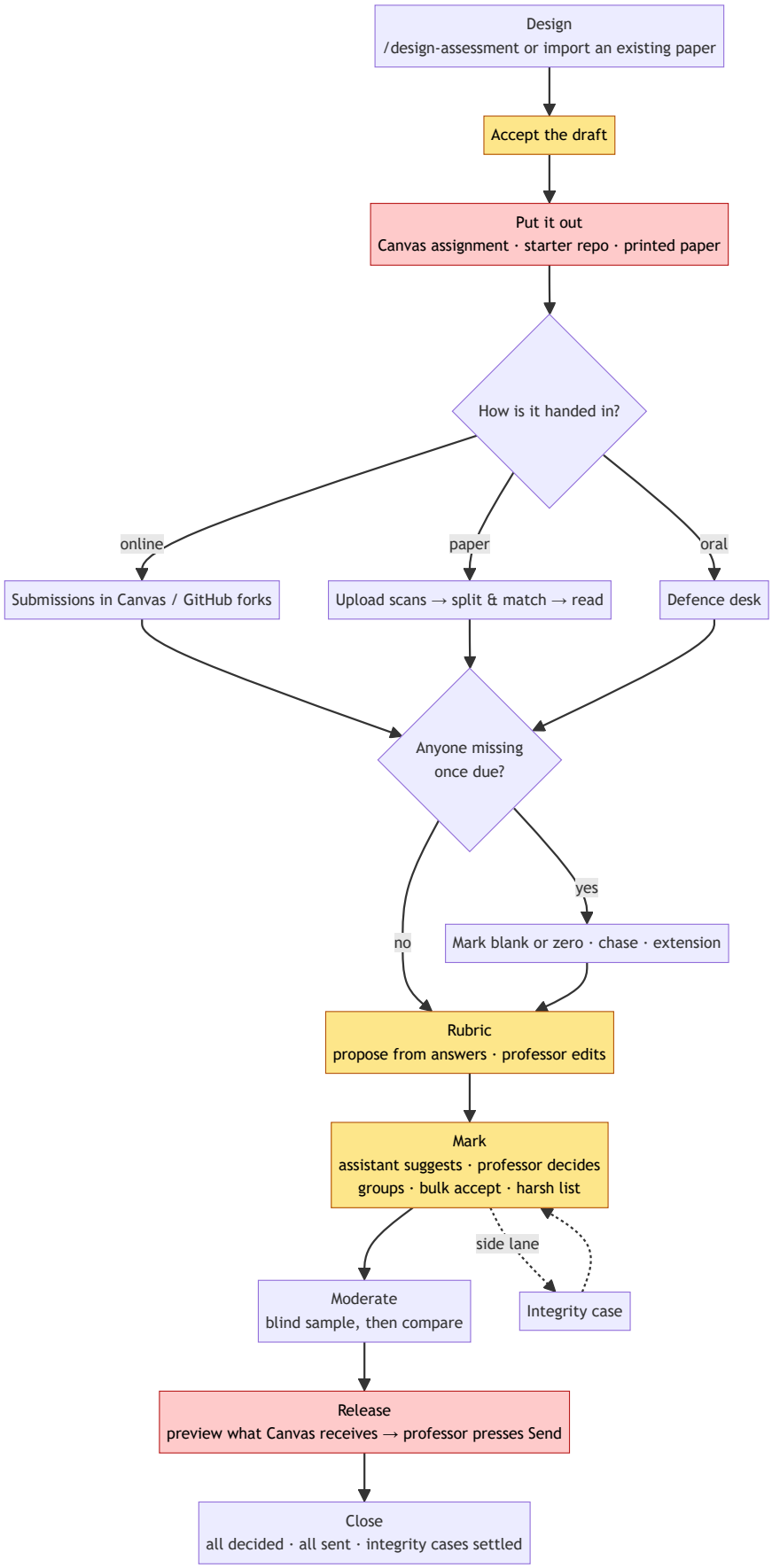
Expectations this loop sets.

- *Week N* is the object. Every gap, draft and deadline the loop touches is on the week card — COURSE-MODE built this, and it is the portal's strongest part.
- *Prepare lesson* reads last week's evidence. The professor expects the brief to know that week N−1's quiz went badly on a concept, without being told. Evidence is keyed by week now, so the link is one press away; the expectation is that it is zero.
- *After class* has no place. A professor who wants to note "concept X did not land, revisit Thursday" has only the chat. A short note on the week card, read by `/prepare-lesson` next time, closes the loop.

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4 · The assessment cycle

The cycle the professor feels most, and the one most scattered across the portal. One assessment is one case; the professor expects to open it once and see where it stands.



Yellow is a **gate** — only the professor's decision moves it. Red is **outward** — a student or Canvas sees the result; it wants a preview of exactly what will be sent and one press.

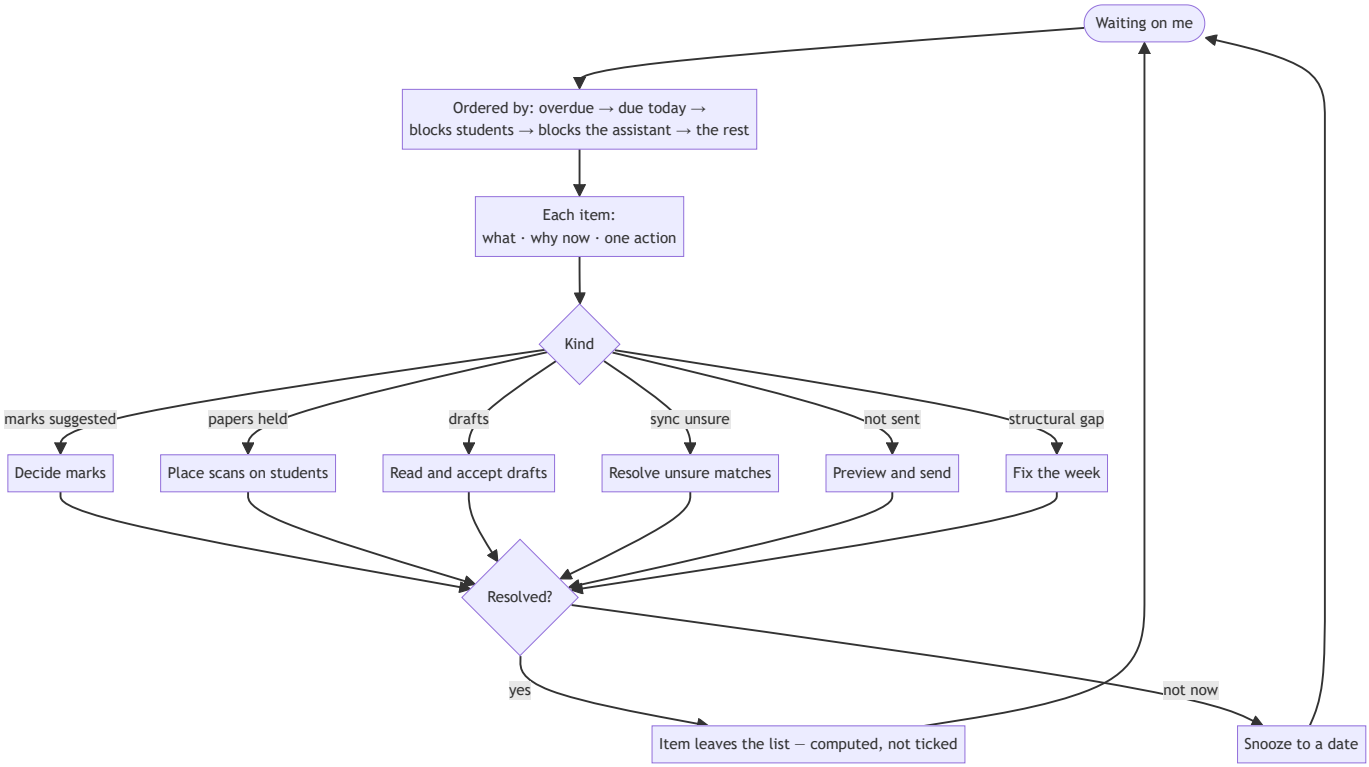
What the professor expects, and where the portal stands.

- **One home per assessment.** Today the week chip shows the step and opens Grade, Scans, the defence desk or Publish over course mode — four windows for one case. The expectation is the strip Scans already has, for every assessment: the stages as dots, the current one as the press, side lanes beside. This is E36 drawn as a screen.
- **Counts, not lists, until asked.** "42 of 60 marked, 6 need you" before any table.
- **Nothing outward without a diff.** Release already previews; publishing an assessment's definition to Canvas should read the same way.

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5 · Daily triage — the "what's waiting on me" list

When the professor's intent is "just clear what's waiting", the portal is an inbox. What they expect from an inbox is familiar from mail: ordered by urgency, each item says what it is, why now, and what one press does.

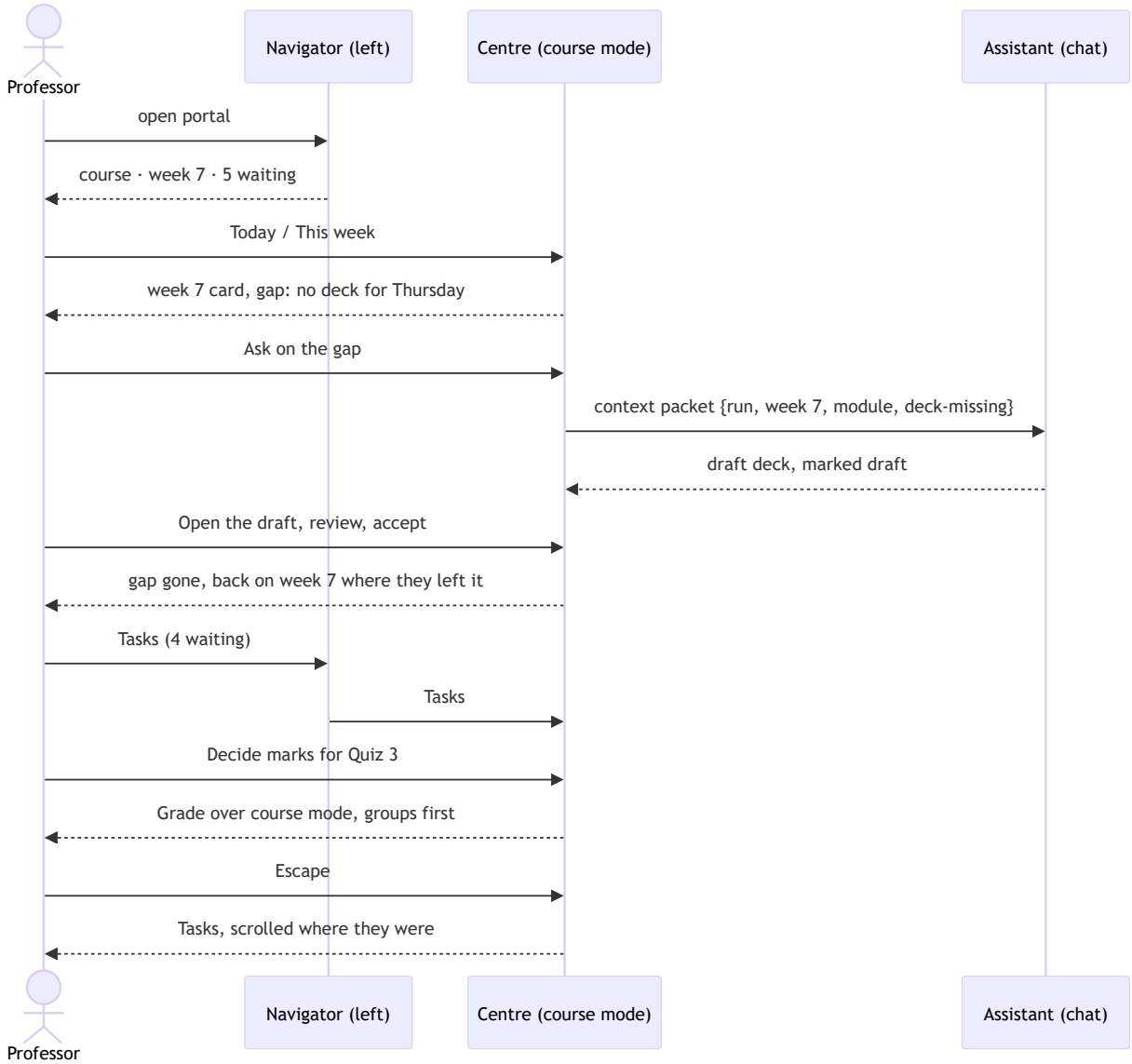


Two expectations the Tasks place does not meet yet: a single **urgency order** across kinds (Tasks groups by Pending · Ready · Checklist, so the professor does the merge), and **snooze** — "not this week" is a real answer a professor gives, and an item they cannot dismiss turns the count into noise.

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6 · How a professor moves around

The pattern under all of the above: **orient → drill down → act → come back to where they were**. Losing the place on return is the most common frustration with tools like this.



The rules this implies, most already held:

- **Escape returns, never resets.** Course mode keeps the weeks mounted beneath a view for this reason.
- **Ask carries context.** The professor never types a week number or an id (UI-1…3).
- **The assistant's output lands as a draft on the object it was asked about**, not only as a chat message.
- **The UI says "the assistant"**, never a model name.

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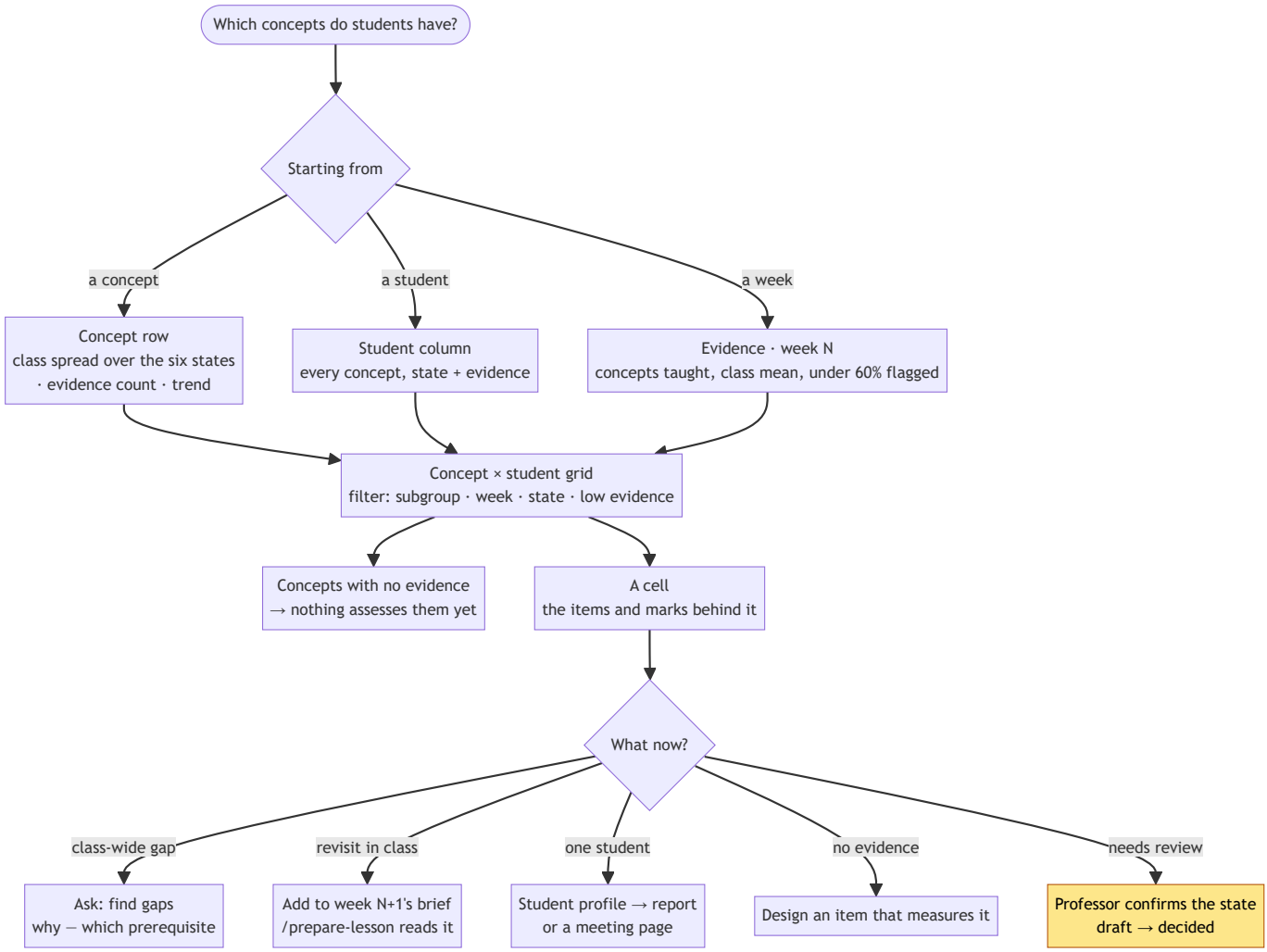
7 · Which concepts the students have

A professor asks this in three shapes, and each starts from a different object:

- **By concept** — "is *gradient descent* landing?" → one concept, the class spread across its states.
- **By student** — "where is Aigerim stuck?" → one student, every concept.
- **By week** — "did last week's topic land?" → the concepts that week taught.

The states are the model's own (`concept_state`): *not observed* · *introduced* · *developing* · *demonstrated* · *consistently demonstrated* · *needs review*. The professor expects to see them as one grid — concepts down, students across, a colour per state — with three things the grid alone does not say: which concepts have **no**

evidence yet (nothing assessed them — `concepts_with_no_evidence`), **how much evidence** a cell rests on (one quiz item is not a verdict), and **why** a cell is red.



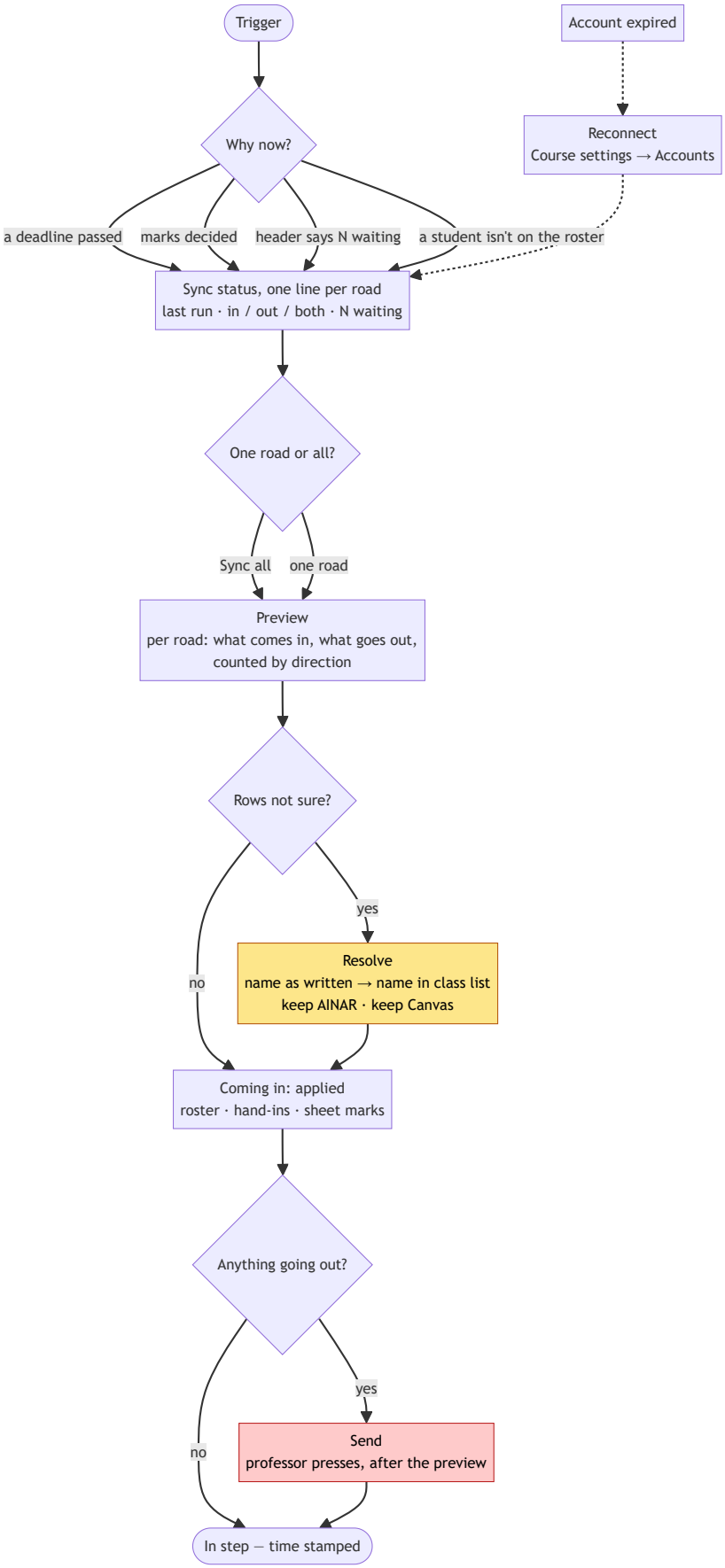
Today. *Concepts* in the navigator draws `class_progress` — the class by concept. Evidence keys concepts by week. One student's concepts are a chat request (`/student-dashboard`), not a place. **Expected:** the grid as the Concepts place, with the student column one press from Students and the concept row one press from a week's concept chip — the same document, entered from three sides. It is private, names follow the Names / Pseudonyms switch, and it never appears on anything a student sees.

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8 · Synchronising the integrations

The run talks to four services: **Canvas** (class list, hand-ins, grades, assignments), **Google Sheets** (the grade sheet the professor keeps, a gradebook copy), **GitHub** (homework forks) and **Telegram** (the channel). Each road has a direction — coming in, going out, or both.

What the professor wants from sync is the opposite of what they want from setup. *Connecting* Canvas happens twice a term; *checking it is in step* happens every week, usually after a deadline or before releasing marks. The two are one place today (Course settings → Integrations), so the weekly action lives behind the twice-a-term door.



Today. Each service's card in Integrations has its syncs with Preview / Run, the waiting rows beside them, and *Sync all* for Canvas differences; course mode's header carries *Canvas: connected · 5 waiting* and opens it. The rules — what may be sent, what is held, what needs `--confirm` — live in `ainar sync`, and stay there. **Expected:**

- **Sync is an operation, not a setting.** A sync strip — one chip per service, last run, waiting count — on the landing, with *Sync all* beside it. Settings keeps *connect*, *reconnect* and the choice of roads.
- **One preview for all roads**, grouped by service and direction, then one Send for everything outward — never a send per road.
- **Waiting rows join the triage list** (§5) as one item per service, not a separate queue.

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9 · Every action, and where it starts

The portal does about fifty things. The table lists them by the object they act on, with how often a professor does each, who does the work, whether it is outward, where it starts today, and where it should start.

Who: P — the professor decides or presses; A — the assistant drafts (a `/skill` in the session); S — the pane or CLI does it deterministically. **Out:** ● — students or a service see the result.

Course and term

#	Action	How often	Who	Out	Today	Should start from
T1	Set up a course	once	A+P		chat `/onboard-course`	Today, pre-term readiness
T2	Connect Canvas, Google, GitHub, Telegram	once	P		Course settings	Course settings
T3	Import the class list (first time)	once	S		CLI `ainar roster import`	Students, empty state
T4	Build the concept map	once	A+P		chat `/propose-concepts`	Concepts, empty state
T5	Plan the term — weeks, meetings, exam shells	once	A+P		`/plan-term`, Weeks · Planning	Weeks · Planning
T6	Set or change the grading policy	rare	A+P		Gradebook policy editor, `/grading-proposal`	Gradebook
T7	Check outcomes against assessments	once	A		chat `/syllabus-review`; no view	Today, pre-term readiness
T8	Publish the course page	term + updates	S+P	●	Publish	header Publish
T9	Close the term	once	P	●	nowhere	Today, after the final
T10	Reflect on the term	once	A+P		chat `/course-reflection`	Today, after close

Week

#	Action	How often	Who	Out	Today	Should start from
W1	See this week	weekly	S		navigator *This week* → Teaching	**Today**
W2	Fix a week's gaps (deck, deadline, room)	weekly	P		Planning chips	Week card
W3	Draft materials	weekly	A		Ask on a gap, `/make-materials`	Week card gap
W4	Read and accept drafts	weekly	P		open the record, Tasks	Waiting list
W5	Edit a title, room or deadline	ad hoc	P		pencil on the item	Week card
W6	Move a topic to another week	rare	P		Planning drag	Weeks · Planning
W7	Prepare the lesson	weekly	A		chat `/prepare-lesson`	Today → this week
W8	Announce to students	weekly	A+P	●	`/publish-telegram`, Publish	Week card, Publish
W9	Note what did not land	weekly	P		chat only	Week card, after class

Assessment

#	Action	How often	Who	Out	Today	Should start from
E1	Design an assessment	per item	A+P		`/design-assessment`	Week card, assessment slot
E2	Import an exam already given	per item	A+P		`/import-assessment`	Upload
E3	Put it out (Canvas, starter repo, paper)	per item	S+P	●	Publish, Integrations	Assessment home
E4	Upload scans	per paper exam	S		Files → Scans, week chip	Assessment home, Upload
E5	Place held papers on students	per paper exam	P		Scans	Waiting list
E6	Run an oral defence	per defence	P		defence desk	Assessment home
E7	Set missing work to blank or zero	per item	P		run or assessment setting	Assessment home
E8	Propose and settle the rubric	per item	A+P		Grade	Assessment home
E9	Decide marks	per item	P		Grade	Waiting list → assessment
E10	Moderate — a blind sample	per item	P		nowhere	Assessment home
E11	Release marks to Canvas	per item	P	●	Grade, Publish	Assessment home
E12	Open an integrity case	rare	P		nowhere	Assessment home, side lane

Student

#	Action	How often	Who	Out	Today	Should start from
P1	Look a student up	ad hoc	S		Students	Students, or search
P2	See their concepts	ad hoc	S		chat `/student-dashboard`	Student → concepts column
P3	Write a report on them	ad hoc	A		chat `/student-report`	Student
P4	Grant an extension or exception	ad hoc	P		nowhere	Student, or assessment row

Concept

#	Action	How often	Who	Out	Today	Should start from
C1	See the class by concept	weekly	S		Concepts (`class_progress`)	Concepts
C2	See concept × student coverage	ad hoc	S		partly, in Concepts	Concepts grid
C3	Find concepts nothing has assessed	per term	S		count only	Concepts, Today readiness
C4	Ask why a concept is not landing	weekly	A		chat `/find-gaps`	Concept row
C5	Confirm a state marked *needs review*	ad hoc	P		record	Waiting list

Integrations

#	Action	How often	Who	Out	Today	Should start from
I1	See whether everything is in step	weekly	S		course mode header line	**Today, sync strip**
I2	Preview a sync	weekly	S		service card	sync strip
I3	Sync all roads	weekly	S+P	•	Canvas card *Sync all*	**Today, sync strip**
I4	Resolve unsure matches	weekly	P		service card	Waiting list
I5	Re-import students from Canvas	ad hoc	S+A		`/sync-roster`	Students, sync strip
I6	Reconnect an expired account	rare	P		Accounts	sync strip warning → Accounts

Overview and the room

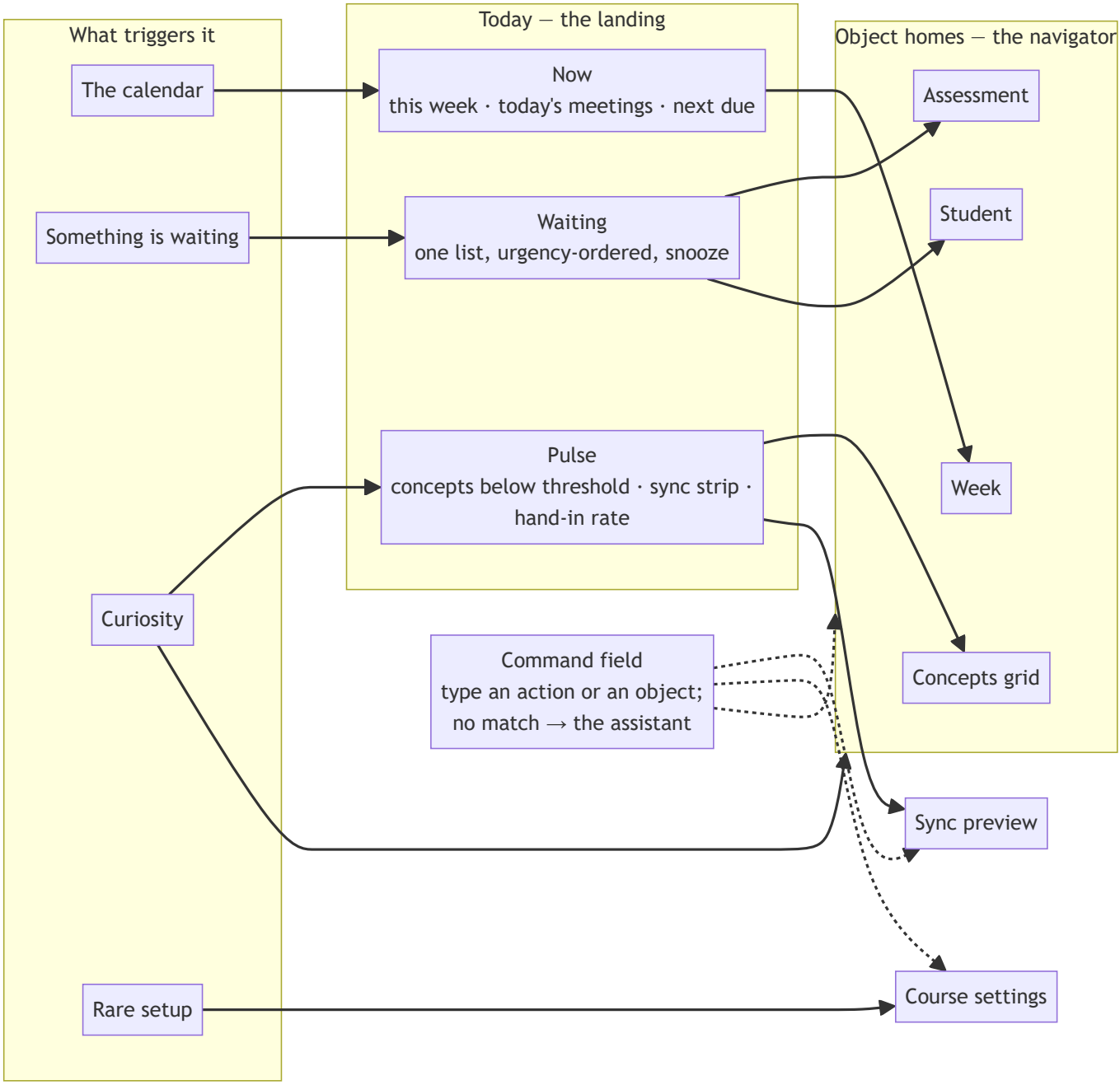
#	Action	How often	Who	Out	Today	Should start from
O1	What is waiting on me	daily	S		Tasks, `/action-inbox`	**Today, waiting list**
O2	How the class is doing	weekly	S		Evidence, Gradebook, `/course-dashboard`	Today pulse → Evidence
O3	Status across all courses	daily	A		`/course-status`	course switcher
O4	Switch course	ad hoc	S		navigator	navigator
O5	Preview as a student	ad hoc	S		course mode	header
O6	Names or pseudonyms (projector)	per class	S		toggle	header
O7	Ask anything	any	A		chat	the field at the foot of every place

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10 · What the entry point should be

Fifty actions do not fit in a navigator, and most of them should never be looked for: they should **arrive**. Sorting the table by what *triggers* each action, not by what it acts on, gives four kinds:

Trigger	Share	Examples	The professor's stance	Entry point
The calendar	~20%	W1, W7, W8, T9, the phase	*it's that time*	Today — **Now**
Something is waiting	~30%	W4, E5, E9, C5, I4, a held sync	*I'm needed*	Today — **Waiting**
Curiosity	~30%	P1, P2, C1, C2, O2, I1	*let me look*	the object's place, Today's **Pulse** as a doorway
Rare setup	~20%	T2, T6, I6	*once a term*	Course settings



The recommendation.

1. **Today is the entry point.** Three bands — *Now*, *Waiting*, *Pulse* — and nothing else. It replaces the empty chat page as the centre on opening, and its content changes with the phase (§2).
2. **Every action has exactly one home**, the object it acts on — week, assessment, student, concept — or Course settings. Today never hosts an action; it **surfaces** one, as a link into its home, when its trigger fires. This keeps the fifty actions from piling up on one screen.
3. **Waiting is one list across every kind** — marks, held papers, drafts, states to confirm, unsure sync rows — computed from the records, so an item leaves when it is done, not when it is ticked.
4. **Pulse carries the two the professor asked for:** concept status (how many below threshold, how many with no evidence) and the **sync strip** (one chip per service, *Sync all*). Both are counts that open a place.
5. **A command field** at the foot of every place — the chat's text field, which is already there — matches actions and objects first ("sync canvas", "week 7", "Aigerim", "release quiz 3"), and passes anything it does not match to the assistant with the current place as context. It is the entry point for the curious and the expert; Today is the entry point for everyone else.

6. **The navigator stays** as the list of homes: Weeks, Tasks becomes *Waiting*, Students, Gradebook, Concepts, Materials, Files — and Course settings at the foot.

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11 · Gaps between expectation and portal, in priority order

#	Expectation	Today	Smallest step
1	Landing answers *where / waiting / next* with no click	centre opens on an empty chat	**Today** with Now · Waiting · Pulse (§10)
2	One urgency order across waiting items, with snooze	Tasks grouped by kind	sort key on inbox items; snooze date on the item
3	Sync is a weekly operation, one press for all roads	per-service cards inside Course settings	sync strip on Today, one preview, one Send (§8)
4	Concept × student coverage, entered from concept, student or week	class by concept; one student in chat	the Concepts grid, with evidence counts and no-evidence row (§7)
5	One home per assessment, stages visible	four windows from a chip	the Scans strip generalised (E36 / WF-2)
6	Outward actions preview exactly what is sent	Release does; Canvas definition push less so	one preview component for every outward press
7	Find any action by typing	chat only	the foot field matches actions and objects first (§10)
8	After-class note feeds next week's brief	chat only	a note field on the week, read by `/prepare-lesson`
9	A close checklist at term end	nowhere	the Close stage of EXAM-GRADING, at run level
10	Phase-aware entry: readiness before term, summary after	same landing all year	phase computed from dates + records

§10 and this table are carried as work items in `BACKLOG.md` E37 (HOME-1…14).

None of these writes a mark or moves the line in `COURSE-MODE.md`: the pane draws and routes, the professor decides, the assistant drafts.